

Introduction

I love propless Mentalism. However, I'm extremely mindful of the propless tools, principles, effects, and routines I integrate into my professional repertoire. These days, I've come to the simple conclusion that if a propless piece of Mentalism can't allow me to be artistically expressive with the information I'm hoping to divine, and if the procedure can't be done quickly, is well-justified, and done at the very start of the effect, I don't touch it. For my tastes, I like propless Mentalism that can act the same as a billet: get the "necessary evil" over and done with at the very start, and the rest of my time is spent creating a unique and emotionally resonant reveal.

This is why propless name and word divinations are a big no-no for me. Not because they don't work¹, but because I don't like the aesthetic of spending the closing moments of the revelation trying to fish for letters, using the *CUPs* principle, or resorting to methods like the *Repeat It* ploy. I tend to gravitate toward propless principles and effects that can be easily framed as reading systems, and I follow a very simple rule. In fact, the rule is so simple that many propless mentalists forget to include it!

¹ Many of them do, indeed, "work." Now, can they take the participant on the same level of emotional and imaginary journey compared to a name reveal using a billet? In most cases, no! They often treat the name as an arbitrary piece of information, rather than as it being a part of a human being's identity. And, even if mentalists don't agree with this, the way they divine information certainly does.

The intended purpose of the propless effect should still be worth an audience's time, attention, and money. If the deceptive method were to "fail," the participant is still gifted with a worthwhile experience.

This is why I love propless star sign and date-of-birth effects so much. If I notice the most subtle feeling that something went wrong during the procedural part of the method, there's still no harm done! I simply offer my participant their reading, make it an insightful and beautiful experience, and we go about our merry way! I don't bother divining the star sign and/or the date of birth, and, most importantly, my participants are never led to believe my intention was to go down that route. I don't mind failure. What I do mind is building a revelation to a climax only for the final revelation to fall flat. Failures should be minimal, carefully constructed, and designed to increase credibility.

For those who may have skeptical thoughts about propless Mentalism, this approach may be of use to you. This approach will allow you to experiment with any propless piece that piques your fancy, and in the event that the piece goes wrong, you'll share with your participant a justified (and mysterious) reason as to why the demonstration failed. Other mentalists have shared lines for covering a miss when performing a bold piece of Mentalism. My only "issue" with some of these lines is that it can take awhile for the mentalist to "prove" their claim is genuine. Without a

harvested piece of info as your backup, you have to take out your billets or prop, introduce the premise, go through the method's procedure, get them to write something down, peek it, and segue into your reveal. This can be time wasted if the failure of the bold, propless Mentalism effect decreases belief and engagement among your participants and audience members. Also, these vague safety-net lines, I've found², don't work if the expectation created from the failed propless Mentalism effect was of you attempting to read the participant's mind.

To me, when delivered badly, such scripts sound like schoolchildren bragging about doing a cartwheel but saying their arm is a bit sore, so they can't do one at that moment. Such excuses within Mentalism also remind me of old friends of mine in elementary school who would brag about having a girlfriend, but say she "goes to another school." Such excuses only really work on laymen if they already believe, and have PROOF, that the mentalist can, indeed, read minds. Rarely is this ever the case when a mentalist decides to use an ethereal and risky piece of Mentalism as their opener!

These days, I most often use my *Red Dwarf* technique when I want to perform something bold, which can't be justified as a propless reading system, and I don't mind failing. I pair my *Red Dwarf* technique with propless effects such as Peter Turner's *Wish You Were Here* and his *Phantom Dictionary Test*, Nico

² The hard way, unfortunately.

Heinrich's *Cocaine* and *Lego Piece*. To learn more about my theories and opinions on propless Mentalism, I suggest purchasing my e-book, *The Dangerous Allure of Propless Mentalism*³.

³ This PDF contains my purely propless date of birth divination *The Ring of Light*

The Red Dwarf

For my style, taste, and preference, I tend to use a quick general reading as my opening “getting-to-know-you” effect, before advancing my performance to direct, bold, and propless mind-reading. I make the general reading quick, entertaining, and not very insightful, so the reading doesn’t move into *Q&A*. My opening general reading, when I want to move into an effect that’s framed as direct mind-reading, and not completely sure-fire, is treated as a fun personality test, more than anything else. I do this because I love readings, I like keeping my performances as minimal as possible, and it’s the most covert way I know to bank the information I need to make *The Red Dwarf* work: a star sign. You can also secretly discover a person’s star sign via discrete observation, an *Additional Information Billet*, or even getting the participant to choose their star sign from a marked zodiac deck you carry for readings and esoteric experiences.

Rather than divining a star sign you’ve harvested from a participant mere seconds after learning it, save it for later. When, during your performances, you’ve mentally prepared yourself to personally road-test a risky piece of propless Mentalism, proceed as usual. Let’s say your series of *Hanging Statements* and *Fishing* has led you to believe your participant is thinking of the name, “Steve.” However, at the moment of truth... the participant says aloud that they were thinking of their father... “Mike.” Rather

than spew out your ten-minute tangent on how “mind-reading doesn’t work on everyone,” I would suggest keeping your cool, pausing for a moment, and saying,

“It’s interesting that I couldn’t pick up on the fact that your father’s name is Mike. I don’t want to make tasteless excuses, but there is one group of people I simply can’t read. I should have asked you this question before we began this demonstration; however, given that I guessed incorrectly about your father’s name, there’s no doubt how you would have answered. Peyton, be honest with me... you’re a Capricorn, correct?”

From this point on, you can now easily and comfortably segue into any sure-fire routine you’ve prepared for the group!

The Red Dwarf

Group Variation

This minor variation to the *Red Dwarf* is great when within a group context, you intuitively feel to perform a bold piece of Mentalism for one individual, but have secretly harvested the star sign from another. The scripting begins in the same way as in the original, but with a slight twist,

Mentalist: *“It’s interesting that I couldn’t pick up on the fact that your father’s name is ‘Mike.’ I don’t want to make tasteless excuses, but there is one group of people I simply can’t read... What’s your star sign?”*

Participant: *“I’m a Capricorn, why?”*

Mentalist: *“Abh, I fucking thought so! For whatever reason, Capricorns are people I simply can’t read! That must explain why my ex always mentioned I was always clueless about her needs...”*

The performer brings his attention to another person (the one whose star sign has been secretly harvested).

Mentalist: *“You, on the other hand, I feel I can receive thoughts a lot easier than with your friend. I say this for one reason: just a ‘yes or no’, are you a Capricorn?”*

The newly chosen participant answers in the negative.

Mentalist: *“Hahah, thank Christ! I thought so! Just to ensure my calibration is correct this time, you’re a Virgo, correct?”*

After this super clean and phenomenal hit on a stranger’s star sign, the mentalist segues into a routine he knows will not only work, but knock the socks off everyone in the group!

Closing Thoughts on 'The Red Dwarf'

A lot of propless Mentalism is experimental and expensive, so it's important that if you do take the plunge into learning more about the subject, you have a professional-grade technique to experiment with what you're learning without your reputation as a mentalist being at risk. The *Red Dwarf* has been a trusty ally during moments when I woke up feeling bold and wanting to masterfully divine the very thoughts of my participants without needing anything written down or typed into an app.

By having a trusted safety net ready to go anytime you want to experiment with something bold and not sure-fire, you'll be able to include such propless Mentalism effects into your performances more often. And, as a result, you'll be quickly on your way to developing, road-testing, and creating your own style of propless Mentalism that fits your voice, character, and comfort level. That is the power and level of creative freedom techniques like *The Red Dwarf* offer to mentalists. A way to experiment with new ideas without the risk of giving your participants and audiences an embarrassing and boring experience.

Always remember, failures can be powerful; they just have to be carefully considered where they can occur in the demonstrations of a real, empathetic, and professional mentalist.

At their best, failures increase credibility and make the performer appear more human and relatable to the audience. At their worst, they decrease engagement, cause audiences to not take the performer seriously, and the mentalist comes across as some jackass who **THINKS** they can read minds. Don't be the jackass.